



My theme and story are unconventional. I am using cricket to counter politics. The cricket club slams politicians and the *chhakka* is their way of protest.

RAJ CHAKRABARTY, Director of *Le Chhakka*



(CLOCKWISE FROM FAR LEFT) RITUPARNO GHOSH PLAYING CHAPAL BHADURI WITH INDRANIEL SENGUPTA IN *AREKTI PREMIER GOLPO*; ARPITA CHATTERJEE IN *EKTI TARAR KHOJE*; ASPIRING CRICKETER DEV IN *LE CHHAKKA*

switched to aggressive marketing and all-round Bengali content such as the upmarket *Jara Brishtite Bhije chilo* by national award-winner Anjan Das. This was followed by singer-director Anjan Dutt's *Madly Bangali* which sent out signals that the staid, conservative Bengali was willing to party. The film was about city youngsters trying to make it big on the music scene. Dutt returned again with *Chalo Let's Go*, a travelogue based on changing relationships starring Saswata Chatterjee, Parambrata Chatterjee and Churni Ganguly. Both of Dutt's films were made for between Rs 50 lakh and 70 lakh, and both were hits.

It's not just Dutt; other filmmakers are also laughing all the way to the bank. Like the director duo of Abhijit Guha and Sudeshna Roy whose glam doll Payel Sarkar-starrer *Cross Connection* ran for a record-breaking 10 weeks in central Kolkata. Roy says, "I had made a film, *Teen Yaarir Kotha*, two years back. It was a *hat ke* film but I could not get it released then. I wish it had been made now." Star-turned-producer Rituparna Sengupta is waiting for the release of *Potadar Kirti* later this year. The film, also starring Priyanshu Chatterjee from Mumbai and Firdaus from Dhaka, is about a don who falls in love with a movie star,

and has been shot on a budget of Rs 80 lakh. "Nothing like this has ever been attempted before. The fact that the film is not heroine-centric, though I am the producer, shows I mean business," says Sengupta.

But how is the industry minting money while interest rates run high? Suvojit Roy, CEO of Orion Entertainment, a company which is set to release its own film *Jodi Ekdin*, says, "A producer can earn from a few verticals— theatre release, satellite rights, home video rights, music rights and overseas rights. In the case of a Rs 60 lakh film, the element of risk is minimal. For a film like *Madly Bangali*, it is easy to conclude that the producer made money from all the four sources put together." *Jodi Ekdin*, starring Indraneil Sengupta and Priyanka Sarkar, talks about new age relationships and is being made on a budget of Rs 65 lakh.

The big divide between urban and rural viewers, that widens every year, has stymied the growth of Bengali films. Mainstream films did not have takers in the city till now. Theatres, as many as 300 of them, had closed down in the past decade. Actor and executive producer Arindam Sil, 45, started the trend of such crossover films as the then executive producer of the Moxie Group with *Bong Connection*, a Rs 1-crore film starring Shayan Munshi, Raima Sen and Victor Banerjee in 2007. "This should have caught on a long time back, but at least it is happening now. The mindset of the youth is changing and the gap between the rural and urban psyches is narrowing," says Sil. He adds, "Compared to the 45 films that were made in Bengal in the past year, at least 80 releases are scheduled for this year."

Despite this, the involvement of corporate biggies has been minimal, barring a few exceptions like RPG Enterprises' Saregama which was behind arthouse films like Rituparno Ghosh's *Khela* in 2008 and Rabiranjan Moitra's debut *Mantra* in 2005, both not so successful. Thirteen new multiplexes have opened—eight in Kolkata, one each in Durgapur, Asansol and Darjeeling, and two in Siliguri. Ratnavali Dutta, assistant manager,